GOUGÈRES

MAKES	ACTIVE TIME	TOTAL TIME	OVEN
about 30 hors d'oeuvres at 4 cm, or 8 to 10 pastries at 10 cm	**30 min**	**about 1 h**	**350F / 180C for about 25 min**

INGREDIENTS

300 ml	Nonfat milk
140 g	Unsalted butter
1 tsp	Salt, for the paste
140 g	All-purpose flour
5	Eggs, large
85 g	Gruyère, grated, plus more for sprinkling
1 tbsp	Fresh thyme, minced
1 tsp	Black pepper, freshly ground
1	Egg, large, for the wash
a pinch	Salt, for the wash

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F / 180C. Butter a baking sheet, or line one with parchment paper.
2. Put the milk, the butter and the salt into a heavy saucepan over medium heat. Hold it there until the butter has gone and the whole thing is at a rolling boil.
3. Tip in all the flour at once and beat it hard with a wooden spoon. Keep working it for about 3 minutes, until the paste is a single smooth mass that comes away from the pan sides and has shed some of its water.
4. Scrape the paste into a stand mixer bowl fitted with the paddle, or into a heatproof bowl if you are doing it by hand.
5. On medium speed, add the eggs one at a time, letting each one vanish into the paste before the next goes in. By the fifth egg it will be very thick, smooth and glossy. A wooden spoon does the same job, one egg at a time, worked in the same order.
6. Lift the bowl off the stand and fold in the cheese, the pepper and the thyme with a rubber spatula.
7. Load a piping bag fitted with a 12 mm plain tip, no. 6 or 7, putting in only as much paste as is comfortable to handle.
8. Pipe 2.5 cm mounds onto the prepared sheet, leaving about 4 cm between them. A spoon dropping 2.5 cm mounds works just as well.
9. Beat the wash egg with a pinch of salt and brush the top of each mound lightly, then scatter a little extra cheese over them.
10. Get the sheet into the oven straight away. Bake about 25 minutes, until they have puffed, browned nicely, and feel light for their size.
11. Serve them hot or warm, or let them come down to room temperature.

NOTES

For the 10 cm size, spoon out 7.5 cm rounds standing about 2.5 cm high, spaced 5 cm apart, wash and cheese them the same way, and bake 35 to 45 minutes until puffed, golden brown and light in the hand. Pierce the side of each one as it leaves the oven so the steam can get out, or they sink. The small ones do not need this. Let them reach room temperature if you intend to split and fill them.

Nonfat milk, not whole. The paste already carries a lot of butter and cheese, and the extra fat in whole milk collapses the large gougères. Half water and half whole milk will do, or water alone.

Gruyère is the default, but Cheddar, Swiss or any other low-moisture cheese works. The full teaspoon of pepper is there to cut the richness of the cheese.

The paste takes other flavourings without complaint — duxelles of minced sautéed mushroom and shallot, caramelised onion, chopped herbs, pimentón, curry.

To bake them later, pipe the mounds onto a sheet, freeze them and store covered. The 2.5 cm ones go into the oven straight from frozen with 5 to 10 minutes added, while the large ones have to thaw first. Baked gougères are at their best the same day, keep a few days in an airtight container in the fridge, and come back with 5 minutes at 350F / 180C.